The final chance to be heard on King's Cross

Forum
Opinion in the CNJ

We have to call the King's Cross property developers to account, claims community leader Satnam Gill

Satnam Gill at the King's Cross gasholders

MY first memory of King's Cross, arriving from Bombay aged eight on a bitterly cold night in February 1963 was of a freezing but snowless station eerily empty and quiet – quite unlike either Bombay's enormous and crowded Victoria Terminus or the snow-locked Bradford we got to at 5am.

My next visit was for a 1971 Maggie Thatcher 'Milk Snatcher' demonstration, when I stayed overnight in the Stanley Buildings and took a closer look at the area, still with its fruit and veg wholesalers and working gas holders.

I have now lived or worked in Camden for almost 30 years throughout which King's Cross has been desperate for redevelopment.

Various redevelopment schemes promising hundreds of homes, thousands of jobs and lots of financial goodies, have fallen by the wayside as a result of community opposition, collapses in the office market, indecision about the Euro terminal or because they were just plain daft.

Today with the Euro terminal almost open at King's Cross, the current proposal from Argent looks like a real possibility and a massive consultation is underway led by the King's Cross Development Forum with more than 200 organisations and residents involved.

After three years as chair of the forum, I now realise the development process is really complex with all sorts of agencies having their hands in the honey pot including the mayor of London, Transport for London, Network Rail, Camden and Islington councils and the Office of the Deputy Prime Minister. Camden and Islington have done the best they can to make the process easy for us to follow.

After more than a year of waiting, we have details of Argent's revisions. There is some positive response to our demands but still considerable uncertainty. Argent no doubt will meet the planning requirements of the two councils and Ken Livingstone but will they meet the community's needs?

Argent may have to make money to cover costs and satisfy shareholders. Our priorities are quite different. There will be changes to King's Cross, but for real improvement the scheme must be integrated with the community and satisfy its needs. We want homes, jobs, kids using sports facilities, parks and a safe, attractive and environmentally-sound development.

We welcome the positive responses Argent have made to our demands. These are:

- Around 1,700 flats and a promise with many 'lifetime housing' units – we would like more;
- Some large family homes with up to 10 per cent four beds and up to 20 per cent three beds;
- 650 places for students;
- 40 per cent affordable housing – we would like at least 50 per cent affordable housing with 35 per cent social housing;
- A meeting space for community groups, two health centres, a children's centre with a nursery and a two-form entry primary school;
- A 25m swimming pool, public sports hall with courts for basketball, volleyball and five-a-side, a number of parks with an increase in green spaces and a range of schemes to encourage bicycle use.
- There may be libraries, a nursing home, higher education provided including for the University of Arts, a multi-faith centre, arts spaces and enhanced facilities for boat users.

We are told there is to be a good employment and training package to give people a chance to get some of the 30,000 jobs on the site but we need great detail to see how this will work. There is no adult education provided despite the need of many in our communities and people who will be working on the site.

We have serious concerns about the heights of the buildings and their density, the lack of detail about design although we have been promised a three-dimensional model and the sustainability of the buildings. We are also determined to seek greater certainty as to when the community services will be delivered.

This development is important for Camden and Islington. If you want to be involved, come to our meetings, from 7pm to 9pm, today, Thursday at the German Gym, Pancras Road, and hear what Argent have to say.

At the gym on Monday, October 17, we will look at environmental sustainability, employment and training. On Thursday, October 20, at The Working Men's College an open session will discuss what we want in Section 106. At the gym on Monday, October 24, we will discuss the Islington Triangle. The consultation closes on November 11.

This is the only opportunity to reshape this vital piece of London. Make sure your views are included by writing to the King's Cross teams at Camden or Islington councils and send a copy to me at The Working Men's College, 44 Crowndale Road, NW1 1TR.

Satnam Gill is the Principle of the Working Mens' College.